The Half-Life of Maria Montlavo

When they dug the softball field up, they found the bones of the old Ursuline nuns who had been buried there. The construction had come to a halt as Sr. Jo and the contractors scratched their heads and tried to proceed with the matter delicately – without stirring undue panic among the students. But of course, as Anna Kat remained in her physics class, her classmates piled against the windows, palms pressed to the glass. They watched as Sr. Jo strode across the grass in a huff, muttering into a phone. Anna Kat did not approach the window, but did hold her book in front of her face, tilting her head to peer through a gap between Eliza Duffy's arm and Claire McEwen's head. She was not above the morbid curiosity of wanting to see a dead nun's bones. Poor Dr. Kim stood at the front of the classroom, chalk in hand, trying to draw the girls' attention away from the hubbub outside.

"Ladies, if you'll please be seated—"

An immense sigh passed between the girls, and slowly they made their way back to their desks. There were only a few minutes before the end of the day, and everyone was more interested in their club meetings and sports practices (most especially the softball players) than Dr. Kim's drab discussion of electron behavior. Anna Kat was usually fascinated by Dr. Kim's lectures, but the newly desecrated nun cemetery had somewhat rattled her. She was eager to retreat to her shift in the library, where there were no windows facing the softball diamond and she could quietly collect her thoughts. She pushed her thick glasses further up the bridge of her nose, inhaling deeply as she tried to regain her focus. Dr. Kim continued.

"Does anyone *not* understand how an electron can be both a particle and a wave at the same time?"

All of the girls raised their hands. Anna Kat sheepishly did too, and at this Dr. Kim looked especially defeated, pinching his eyebrows between his thumb and forefinger. The bell rang and Ms. Ayotte in the secretary's office cleared her throat over the intercom. Everyone rushed to pack their bags. Dr. Kim cupped his hands around his mouth so as to be heard over the bustling students.

"*Ladies!* Silence for the afternoon prayer!"

Everyone froze and began reciting with Ms. Ayotte.

Saint Angela watch over the days of our youth, Saint Ursula protect our futures.

Dr. Kim crossed himself and clapped his hands together. "Well, then I suppose we'll have to pick up with electric fields next class. Don't forget about your Chapter 6 homework due next Monday and have a nice weekend!"

"Thank you!" Each girl said as they left the classroom. "Thank you!"

"Thank you," said Anna Kat, offering a small wave between her stack of books. Dr. Kim waved her a warm goodbye and sat at his desk to begin grading.

Anna Kat mulled over the events of the day as she turned out of the classroom and down the staircase, to the library. She scanned her student ID, and took her seat behind the desk, breathing a sigh of relief.

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Maria Montlavo was dead. This was not news to her; she had been dead for over half a century. What bothered Maria the most was that the Ursuline nuns were far deader than she – nearly two hundred years deader – and they had been found first. Maria's own skeleton lay in the

rafters of the attic which had long been cemented off from the faculty and student body. She couldn't remember how it got there, and sometimes Maria thought it – and by extension, she – might be there forever. She stared out the windows of Dr. Kim's physics classroom, comfortably watching the commotion from between a girl named Elizabeth and her friend Claire. Maria took a brief note of the space she created within in the frenzied crowd of girls.

Even when she tried to touch the living girls, she found she simply could not. The living moved from her touch, naturally so, in the same way electrons repelled each other. When Maria was a newer ghost, this fact greatly disappointed her. She would stand in the middle of the hallways and scream and try to tug at the hair or the backpacks of passing students. But just as she reached out, without fail, they would turn to talk to a friend, fiddle with a loose thread on their collar, adjust the strap on their bag. It couldn't be done.

Another thing that bothered Maria was that – despite the passing of sixty years — she still didn't quite understand *why* she was here. Of course, her theology teachers had taught her about purgatory, but she didn't know why she was spending hers in high school. She hated high school. She had tried to leave countless times before, but every time she got too far, she would find herself right back in the attic, a disoriented fluster. Sometimes, it all became so great and so frustrating that she felt she may simply implode. It was at these times that Maria would go to visit Dr. Kim's Physics II lecture.

Today was one of those days, and when Maria entered the classroom, she was especially comforted by the fact that today's lecture was her favorite: electron behavior.

An electron can act as both a wave and a particle, existing in multiple states at once. Undecided and decided. Dead and alive. But the moment you observe it, that uncertainty collapses—it has to be one or the other.

Maria whispered the words along with Dr. Kim; he said this every year. That was, until he was interrupted by the commotion outside. Maria stared at the scene, bitterness rising in her chest. The nuns had surely found their way to heaven long ago. They didn't need to be found.

She had never felt lonelier.

Angry, she left Dr. Kim's classroom and headed down to the library to clear her head. Thankfully, very few living students stayed in the library on Friday afternoons, and there were no windows facing the softball diamond. As she entered, she headed straight for the theology section—she needed to sort out her thoughts.

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Anna Kat loved her Friday afternoon shifts in the library. Usually, the librarian, Mrs. Crane, had her reshelving books. Occasionally, Anna Kat would assist her with making a poster or presentation on the aged computers. Today, Anna Kat was in the theology section of the library, carefully returning twenty-or-so classroom copies of the Catechism to their respective shelf. It was blissfully silent, with only the clacking of Mrs. Crane's keyboard and a lone-standing oscillating fan to break the stillness. If she finished early, Anna Kat would do homework until her eyes were bleary, and Mrs. Crane was locking up for the evening.

Anna Kat hummed to herself as she shelved, eager to begin research where Dr. Kim had left off. The sudden discovery of the old Ursuline burial grounds had distracted her from Dr. Kim's lecture, but she had been intrigued. She was frustrated that she let something so

unremarkable as death pull her focus away from the lecture. In a two-hundred-year-old Catholic school, Anna Kat found herself surrounded by death daily. Class photos dating back to the early 1800s decorated the walls spanning all the way from the library to the science hallway. Jesus hung, nailed to a cross, above every doorway and below every chain of rosary beads. Her teachers spoke of death frequently and fervently. Every good Catholic girl had more than been prepared to face death.

As she thought this to herself, the back of Anna Kat's hand brushed the innermost wall of the bookshelf, and something pried itself loose. She recoiled briefly, startled by the sudden movement. Carefully, she knelt and ducked her head down to inspect. There, Anna Kat saw a thin, leatherbound book, the cover so blanketed in dust that if she hadn't moved it, it would seem like part of the shelf. Anna Kat pressed her cheek onto the floor, reaching for the booklet, which left a clean silhouette against the wood in its wake. She held it to the light, and blew on the cover, which promptly spat dust back into her face. Blinking, she placed her glasses on her head and turned to the first page. In heavily embellished cursive, there read a name.

Maria Montlavo.

Anna Kat paused her shelving and seated herself at the nearest computer. As she leafed through the pages, she found they were half-full of diary entries, most of which were dated sometime between January and April 1971. Each was signed *With Love, Maria Montlavo.*

Many of the entries revealed a girl several years ahead of her time, with a natural skepticism that seemed to leave her with very few friends at St. Angela Merici's. She was clever and inquisitive and had a keen interest in chemistry and physics.

Dr. Fletcher tells me about a physicist named Schrödinger, who proposed that electrons exist in multiple states at once until they are measured, collapsing into a single reality. Do we change when people notice us, too? Who am I when no one is watching?

She was beginning to grow fond of Maria, but as she continued to flip through the pages Anna Kat felt a growing unease. The more she read, the more Maria seemed to reference a particular teacher – her physics professor, Dr. Fletcher. At first, the notes were casual, academic. But slowly, Maria's writing grew more and more nervous.

He says I have a 'scientific mind' and that I ask the kinds of questions no one else dares to. I ought to feel flattered, but something about the way he lingers unsettles me.

Anna Kat frowned and continued.

I tried to tell Sr. Miriam that I don't like being alone with him, but she told me I was imagining things. That Dr. Fletcher was a respected professor, and I should be grateful he's taken such an interest in my studies.

Maria's handwriting had become shaky, the words pressed harder into the paper.

I'm an altar server this week. Dr. Fletcher offered to help me fetch the unconsecrated Eucharists from storage and walk me to the chapel afterwards. I told him no.

She flipped through the next few pages — blank. There was no explanation, no sign-off. Just empty space where Maria's thoughts should have been.

Anna Kat paused, allowing the booklet to fold to a close on her hand. She had never heard of a Maria Montlavo or Dr. Fletcher at St. Angela Merici's.

Anna Kat stirred the mouse in front of her, and the computer blinked to life. In the search engine she typed, 'Maria Montlavo St. Angela Merici College Prep. Several PDFs of newspaper archives appeared in the search results.

Parents Sue St. Angela Merici College Preparatory School, Outraged Over Missing Daughter.

Anna Kat's eyes bulged, and she clapped a hand to her mouth, stifling a gasp. Mrs. Crane who had been fully engrossed in her work, jumped a bit and shushed her with a scowl. Anna Kat blushed and shrunk back in her chair, mouthing a bashful '*sorry.'* She returned her attention to the computer.

Oh, God. She thought.

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If Maria had a breath, she would have held it. When she was alive, the theology section of the library had been her early-morning solace—a quiet sanctuary before the weight of the day settled onto her shoulders. Her grandfather used to gift her small, handmade booklets that she would fill with her thoughts and musings in the precious minutes before the school bell rang. The day she died, she had stuck her most recent booklet at the bottom-most library shelf as her physics professor approached her. She had meant to come back for it later.

Later had never come for Maria.

Now, seeing the booklet again, Maria felt something long dormant stir inside her. She remembered *why* she had felt so inclined to hide her book from Dr. Fletcher. Maria curled her fingers into her palms and her nails dug into her unfeeling flesh. Slowly, she sank into the chair

next to the girl who held her diary. Maria's gaze drifted to the student ID around the girl's neck, and her eyes lingered for a moment.

Anna Katherine Murphy.

She recognized the name immediately. Anna Katherine was in Dr. Kim's Physics II class. Maria had noticed her before, but she had been so reserved that Maria had never paid her much mind. Now, however, as Anna Katherine flipped through the pages of her own diary, something shifted. Maria's heart quickened and a fragile and tentative hope unfurled in her chest. Anna Katherine was looking for answers.

She's looking for me.

Anna Katherine stood suddenly, the chair scraping loudly against the floor. Her glasses were askew, and her hair tousled from absentmindedly running her fingers through it. She looked disturbed. Maria stood as well and silently followed Anna Katherine as she moved toward Mrs. Crane's desk. Maria vaulted the desk and settled onto the countertop, leaning in with anticipation.

"Excuse me?" Anna Katherine asked, her voice shaky but determined. "Excuse me?"

Mrs. Crane glanced up, her brows lifting as she adjusted her half-moon glasses with a slight frown.

"Would you happen to know when the pantry for the chapel was built?"

Mrs. Crane blinked and her eyes dulled as she sifted through the years in her mind. Maria watched her closely—she had been there when the pantry had been built.

"Well," Mrs. Crane said, pausing, "That would have been during my second year here—1971, I believe. There's a placard dedicating it to the class of ’71, if you’d like to go take a look at it. It’s in the hallway.”

"Lovely," Anna Katherine said, her voice quiet as she took the new piece of information in. "And where would the supplies for Mass have been stored before that?"

The attic. Thought Maria.

Mrs. Crane paused, her face registering a moment of surprise before her mind caught up.

"When I was a freshman," she said slowly, "the attic was used for storage—everything from the wine to the priests’ linens. They stopped using it the following year, though. I assumed it was because the place was so drafty and... well, unpleasant. Too cold, too damp, and it smelled awful. The school decided to seal it up after that. Cemented the whole thing shut.”

“Mrs. Crane,” Anna Katherine fixed her gaze, and for a brief moment, Maria felt as though she was looking straight at her. “I think…we need to get into the attic.” She pushed Maria’s diary towards Mrs. Crane.

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Maria tagged closely behind Anna Kat, who tagged closely behind Mrs. Crane and Sr. Jo as they hurriedly made their way to the maintenance ladder behind the chapel.

“How many damn skeletons can there be in one closet,” muttered Sr. Jo. “You’d think we were running a haunted house, not a school.”

Maria’s excitement bubbled as she followed.

"Here," Sr. Jo said, as she thrust old, tarnished keys into Anna Kat's hand. "Do what you need to do, and for heaven's sake, don't make a scene. Mrs. Crane, if you'll please call law enforcement, that would be most helpful."

Mrs. Crane pulled out her phone, holding it an arms-length from her face and squinting as she pressed the numbers. Sr. Jo pinched the bridge of her nose.

"Lordy, the amount of paperwork that's going to come out of this mess."

"Thank you, Sr. Jo," said Anna Kat and she began to climb the ladder.

Maria's fingers trembling slightly as she gripped the rungs. The cold metal felt solid beneath her palms. For a brief second, Maria felt inclined to turn around. Sirens echoed in the distance as Mrs. Crane hurriedly spoke into her phone. The sun was setting over a relatively clear sky. Maria hadn't thought to watch the sun set in decades. She continued to climb. As she approached the top, Anna Kat unlocked a skylight. She threw the latch and swung the window open, then hung her head upside down into the old attic. Maria climbed onto the roof and peered in through the open window from the opposite side. At first, Anna Kat searched the ground. Her eyes fell to the piles of boxes covered yellowed sheets. As she lifted her head for a breath of fresh air, she saw her. Maria. There, in the rafters, uncomfortably crumpled, cobwebs in place of her ligaments, and with a horrible gash in the side of her skull. Anna Kat brought a hand to her mouth. Maria froze.

"I found her!" Anna Kat called from the roof. The sirens grew closer.

She found me thought Maria and then she was gone.